Foreword

The rest of the world says America isn't interested in soccer. I'm not so sure. Every time I visit, I see kids playing in parks and on school and college campuses everywhere. Whenever I turn on the television, it seems there's a game being transmitted from England's Premiership, Spain's La Liga, Italy's Serie A or one of the South American leagues. My old club, Manchester United, played matches in front of capacity crowds coast to coast on their 2003 Summer Tour.

Baseball, Football, Ice Hockey and Basketball are the established team sports in the States, I know. Those sports have their own history and traditions, their superstars and millions of knowledgeable fans. I get the feeling, though, that soccer's time is about to come. Team USA showed how much raw talent there is here at the 2002 FIFA World Cup. Their 3–2 win over Portugal was one of the most impressive performances of the entire tournament. The national women's team has long been one of the best in the world. I found out all about them first hand when I joined the squad for a training day, organized by adidas, last summer. There's a buzz around soccer in the States that points towards a very exciting future. Not interested? I'd say the rest of the world had better watch out.

I've been lucky to have been a pretty regular visitor to America since I was a boy. Time enough to get to know a country that I've grown to love. I have snapshots of wonderful moments locked away in my memory: a teenage soccer tournament in Texas in the late eighties; watching my wife-to-be Victoria onstage at Madison Square Garden with the Spice Girls in the nineties; presenting an award at the MTV Awards Night in Los Angeles last summer. We've had fantastic family holidays here, too, with our sons Brooklyn and Romeo.

If I could take one aspect of American life back to England with me, it would be this country's sense of patriotism: the feeling of a whole nation